

Readings

Judges 12:5-6

Gilead captured the fords of the Jordan at the crossing to Ephraim. If an Ephraimite fugitive said, "Let me cross," the men of Gilead would ask, "Are you an Ephraimite?" and he would say, "No." And they would say, "Say, 'Shibboleth.'" But he would always say, "Sibboleth"—he couldn't say it right. Then they would grab him and kill him there at the fords of the Jordan. Forty-two Ephraimite divisions were killed on that occasion.

Mark 9:38-40

"Teacher," said John, "we saw someone driving out demons in your name and we told him to stop, because he was not one of us."

"Do not stop him," Jesus said. "For no one who does a miracle in my name can in the next moment say anything bad about me, for whoever is not against us is for us. Truly I tell you, anyone who gives you a cup of water in my name because you belong to the Messiah will certainly not lose their reward."

2 Timothy 3:16 - 17

All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the people of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.

Bible Basic Bootcamp

In my work as a chaplain there are two questions that I am asked occasionally before people will allow me to minister to them. I'm given a test to make sure I'm spiritually safe. Unfortunately, the answer is not as easy as having the correct pronunciation of "Shibboleth." People who are very fundamental in their faith need to know that I will not challenge their beliefs or mock their faith while they share vulnerable concerns. So they may ask me about Jesus, or they might ask me about the Bible. They are looking for very specific and short answers. Anything that is vague or sounds like I'm equivocating shuts the door for any further relationship. I've had to figure out ways to respond to these questions so that I can give them the answer they need and also keep integrity with myself and my own faith.

When they ask about the Bible, they want to hear the words "Inspired, Inerrant, Infallible", and "the Word of God." Fortunately, as a Unitarian Universalist minister, I have no trouble saying these words and I fully believe them... perhaps just not in the same way they do. The thing is, I know some things about how the Bible came to be and how to read it.

Let me acknowledge here that talking about the Bible can be very uncomfortable. Many people have been deeply wounded by its misuse. The Bible is a double-edged sword; it's caused tremendous harm as well as remarkable healing. It is also a very complex topic. I only have a short bit of time this morning and so if it seems like I am simplifying a Gregorian knot into a square knot, I am!

The Bible is like a crazy quilt. Each square on the quilt is independent and whole. Yet piecing them all together creates something much bigger, complicated and beautiful. The Bible is made

up of individual, complete literary books. Each book is its own thing and it used to stand alone. Over time, it became known and valued. It became special.

Think about the classic literature we have today. We have books and stories, from Homer's Odyssey to Beowulf to Pride and Prejudice to Catcher in the Rye - all these very different literary works have risen to a place where we understand they are exceptional. Let's take just a moment and I'd like folks to call out the names of your all time favorite books. Quick, what are the ones that you think of? (Name books)

The thing about these works is that when you've read one, you know it's in a league of its own. Like so many of you, I love to read and I'll blast through a bunch of books. But with the exception of Anna Karina, every time I have read something that's been recognized as extraordinary, I've ended with the feeling. "Wow - now I know why this one's a classic!" There's something quintessential about these works. No matter when they were written, they still speak to us today. They cover the big themes. They do so in ways that are unique and timeless. A book that's been on the New York times bestseller list for 24 weeks is just not at the same level as something that people are still reaching for after hundreds of years. These tried and tested, definitive and superior books have been grouped into a canon of classical literature. We consider them inspired. Incidentally, "inspire" comes from the Greek word meaning 'God breathed.'" Inspiration is not dictation. These literary works reflect the personality, styles, and world views of the authors. They are not transcribed word for word from the mouth of God. Rather, these books have life in them.

This is true of the books that made it into the Bible. Thinking back to the millennia before printing presses, there were only two

ways to pass along a good story: oral tradition or hand copying it out. Either way was a tremendous amount of work.

Perhaps you got in trouble in grade school and were punished by having to copy out a page in the dictionary. That took forever! And it was pretty grueling.

In ancient times, just getting the materials to make a book was an effort. Paper or parchment had to be made, there were special recipes for ink. No one had a great feeling gel roller-ball pen that was easy on the hand. They had to use feather quills dipped in refillable ink pots and scratch the letters onto their writing surface. Books were financially costly, labor intensive, time consuming, and precious.

In ancient times there were many religious books floating around. After a time, it became clear which ones were most valuable.

In the 2nd century BCE, the Jews informally gathered the books that belonged to that special class that outshone everything else. There was not a committee that decided what books would go in the Hebrew Bible. Instead it was by common consent. Everybody knew and agreed that these particular books were on a level all of their own. 24 books made it into the Hebrew Canon. They were divided into three scrolls: Instruction, Prophets and Writings.

Religious books and letters continued to be written: stories about Jesus and other spiritual figureheads, theological treatises, instructions to religious groups and explanations of origins. More oral stories were passed down. And the same process happened for the Christian church. People got together and agreed on what the best books were. Again, there was no committee.

In 367, the bishop of Alexandria was the first to write in his festival newsletter a list of all 66 books in the Biblical Canon. These were the classic books that everybody agreed upon. The word "Bible" comes from the Greek word for books, plural. So the Bible is an anthology of the books the early Christians agreed were inspired and worth the time, effort, and money to copy.

The names given to the books are not necessarily their authors. We don't always know who wrote what. They were given those names as a handy way to refer to them. In the same way, chapters and verses were added to the books after they were all put together. Otherwise it was too unwieldy. And like the Hebrew scriptures, the Christian Bible was organized according to types of literature: The Old Testament keeps most of the Hebrew Scriptures, though in a somewhat different order. The New Testament focuses on the specific Christian texts. The Gospels are the stories about Jesus' life. Historical books are about early church life. Letters of instruction and encouragement to the churches, also called Epistles, are the third category, and then the Book of Vision or Revelation is the last.

Today's Catholic Bible contains more apocryphal books in its Old Testament, 46 compared to the Protestant 39. That however, is a whole other history lesson. Today we're just focusing on the Protestant Bible.

Sometimes you'll see advertisements that for just \$29.95 you can get a copy of the Lost Gospels. These are the gospels, they hint, that some mysterious, manipulative and devious, Christian leadership group has hid from you. Actually they are just the gospels that didn't make the cut.

The best known is the Gospel of Thomas. It's a pretty entertaining read. For example, when Jesus was a toddler, he made a mud bird and turned it to life and it flew away. As a child, Jesus got mad at one of his playmates and struck him dead. Then he felt bad about it and brought him back to life. It's an action-packed gospel with more miracles! But it certainly does not have the gravitas of the four standard gospels. Ultimately, readers did not find it as credible.

If you read the four gospels in the New Testament, (Gospel means good news), you'll notice that there are quite a few differences. That is as it should be. If four people see an accident, there will be four different accounts. If you ask them about the incident and all four of them respond with exactly the same sequence of events and words, we are quick to realize that they all got together and collaborated on their story. And we don't trust that. The fact that the gospels don't all say the whole same thing is a testament to their validity, not proof that there are mistakes.

This is a good segue into the idea of inerrancy. There are people who are happy to point out all the ways that they believe scripture is false. The real problem is not that there are lies, errors and fallacies all over the Bible. The problem lies in reading books of the Bible in ways they were not meant to be read and asking them to be what they are not.

Think about a newspaper. While it is one newspaper, we don't read the advice column the same way we read the headlines or examine the financial pages. We don't read the funnies the same way we peruse the real estate ads or respond to the human interest stories. We understand that the genre matters. When people ask the Bible to be a history book, it will seem to be full of mistakes. But there's nothing in the Bible that is intended to be history in the same way we understand history today.

One of my favorite examples is the first two chapters of the book of Genesis. "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth." It's not a history book and it's not science. It is a poem. Quite specifically, it is a polemic. There were lots of stories floating around the ancient world about how the world was created. The most popular was the Mesopotamia Enuma Elish creation myth, which said that there were many gods battling between goodness and evil. When Marduk won, he created the Earth using the body of the defeated evil god.

Genesis is a poem that basically says "Hey, you think your god created the world. Well actually, it was our God who brought it into being, and God did so without any of this ridiculous fighting nonsense. Period." That's the whole point. It's an excellent poem that declares it was the God Yahweh who made everything. It doesn't close the door on evolution, it doesn't tell us how old the world is, it doesn't even tell us the order in which our world developed.

When I watch those amazing Nova documentaries about the formation of our planet, I'm blown away. You don't have to believe in God to acknowledge that some power greater than us has been at work in our universe. And that is pure poetry.

Let me add a bit more about history and the Bible. We have a particular way of understanding events in 21st century America. However, a linear plot line with some tangential exploration of influencing events, along with precise dates and numbers are not important aspects of ancient history. Additionally, in the US, we are our own person, rugged individualists. In other parts of the world, even today, one is not a full person unless they can present their complete lineage. Whose son or daughter, grandchild, and great-great-great-great-grandchild are you? Where do you come from? No one wants to hear from you until you can articulate all of that clearly. That's why people were willing to pay big money to have huge lists of the begats copied. The gospel of Matthew emphasizes Jesus' Jewish and royal heritage, tracing 14 generations from Abraham to David, 14 generations from David to the Babylonian exile, and 14 generations from the exile to Christ. The gospel of Luke traces Jesus's lineage through Mary back to Adam, emphasizing his every man heritage.

We can trust what the Bible says, if we read it according to the way it was intended. If we look at the genre, the word play, the focus of the passage, and the context, we will find that the Bible is accurate within that particular format. If we try to turn it into something we think it should be, like modern written history, it will seem full of errors. Using 21st century American standards, we will find as many mistakes as we want!

Handling the text with integrity reveals it to be an honest collection of books. It also frees us from having to prove anything about it. If we read it the way it was meant to be read, we do not have to prove that it is true or accurate. We do not have to make the science line up. We are also freed from treating it like a magic book! When we become focused on proving the Bible's validity and worth, we are practicing Bibliolatry, idolizing the Bible.

Let me stress here that the Bible is not a magic book and it is not full of conspiracies! If you're in the habit of letting the book drop open and putting your finger down and looking for guidance from the Bible that way, you can use any other book you want. You will get similar results. The Bible does not provide individual direction using magic touch. The direction offered by the Bible is larger and much more complicated.

Further, the Bible isn't full of all sorts of secret codes and hidden conspiracies. It doesn't use numerology to spell out the name of the Antichrist. I think especially of the book of Revelation. I'd love to do a sermon just on that book sometime. Remember, people would not spend the time and money required to copy a book if it didn't mean anything important to them at the time that it was written. If it was all about future prophecies, helicopters, nuclear bombs and JFK, it would not have made sense to ancient readers. They wouldn't have treated it as a classic.

Anytime we try to make the Bible into something that it is not, we end up looking foolish and we miss the opportunity to hear what others have valued for centuries.

One of the extremely unique things about the stories in the Bible is that they are not sugar coated. They are not written to make the king or the Hebrew people look good. As a matter of fact, often the Bible goes out of its way to make them look bad. If you study other ancient literature, you'll find that the kings won all their battles. (If they didn't win, those battles were not recorded!)

Instead, the Bible shows us the mistakes, blunders, foolishness, wisdom, and complexity of its people. Like all classic literature, people are good and bad, they're messy and difficult. And in this way, they are more relatable to readers then and now.

Numbers are handled differently in ancient texts than they are today. Again, we can't place today's standards on ancient literature. But as an example, if I tell you that somebody was 10 feet tall, would you say I was lying? No. You would know what I meant. I was communicating that this person had an uncommon height. We say 6 of 1 and half a dozen of another. We talk about batting a thousand. In our language, numbers are not always numbers.

When today's readers of the Bible want to put a literal interpretation on biblical numbers, it will often seem nonsensical. So many of these numbers may not be literal numbers.

A great case is the number 40. In ancient literature, the number 40 symbolized "complete" or "whole." Think about all the times that number is referenced... It rained for 40 days and 40 nights, the Israelites wandered in the desert for 40 years, Goliath taunted the Israelites for 40 days, the holy Palace of the temple was 40 cubits long, Jesus fasted in the desert for 40 days....

Now I suppose it's possible that 40 is an actual number in these cases, but it doesn't really matter. The meaning is that an event which happened, or the item that was built, was complete. It's similar to our phrase, "in the fullness of time." It's almost a Taoist principle.

Many numbers in the Bible represent more than a specific amount: 3, 7, 12, 40, and 12 times 12 are all illustrations of numbers as figures of speech. While numbers are just one form of figures of speech, it becomes easier to understand how the Bible may be far more trustworthy than we have given it credit for.

Finally, let's talk about infallibility. This is the idea that the Bible can't make mistakes and it is not misleading. The contradictions we encounter can indeed be resolved. Here we begin to deal with theology. One occurrence would be how God changes as one reads through the Bible. In the Old testament, God is jealous, violent, angry, and certainly not very nice! By the time we get to the New Testament, Jesus is referring to God as 'Abba' which means "Daddy."

This is an example of progressive revelation. One begins where people are and then reveals more and different information as people learn and are able to take it in. The Old Testament introduces the idea of monotheism to a world that worshiped many different gods. The gods people knew and understood were generally pretty nasty. This single God must first be understood as a God before unique traits and differences could be taught.

To demand that the Bible communicates the same things throughout the entire set of books as proof of validity would certainly be a waste. There would be no growth, no increased understanding, no grappling with nuance and complexity. If we know anything about

classics, we know that they are not simple and that they often challenge us.

One example that hits close to home for me is how the Bible talks about women. There are places in the Bible that indicate clearly that women don't count; they are chattel, and they should be obedient and remain silent. Yet we also come across instances of women prophets, leaders, and pastors of churches.

Before pointing fingers at the places where we say the Bible is making a mistake, we have to look at genre, the use of language and numbers, how history was understood, what people understood as important, social customs of the time, and the purpose of that particular passage or book.

I admit that I'm biased, yet I believe that when the Bible is handled with integrity, it ultimately supports women in leadership roles in religion.

In the Old testament we hear that homosexuality is a sin and abomination. In the New testament there are instances of Jesus blessing and also seeking out LBGQTQ folks. One of my favorites is when a Roman centurion asks Jesus to heal his "precious servant," which is a euphemism for his male lover, and Jesus doesn't bat an eye. Instead, he praises the centurion, who is not a Jew, for his faith, and heals the servant.

Before the last supper, Jesus tells his disciples to go into town, find a man carrying a jug of water, follow him home and tell the master of that house that Jesus and his disciples will have the Passover meal there. At that time, carrying water was a woman's job. Jesus could have said, "Go into town and find the man wearing a

dress...' but back then all the men were wearing dresses! There is a change, a progression, of how people are understood and treated.

One final complication is that we are dealing with translations. These ancient classical texts were written in Hebrew, Aramaic and Greek. We read modern English translations, or in the case of the King James Version, a not so modern translation. Translations are not a pure science and they transmit theology and the biases of the translators.

Back to my earlier example about women and leadership: there are several places where translators struggle with the roles of women. The Greek word "diakonon" (διδάκων) is translated as Deacon when it is associated with men. When it is associated with women, some translations use the words "helper" or "servant." (Romans 16:1 - 2, and 1 Timothy 3:8 - 13) Some translate it as "deacon's wife," distancing even the role of helper from women in the church.

When I was in seminary, translating passages of the Bible, it was easy to see the theological differences between me and my fellow students by how we chose to word the same passage. The truth is, we don't actually translate into English, we paraphrase, and that always carries our own prejudice.

I really like the Bible - I could go on and on. I'm clear it's a double-edged sword. It would cause far less harm if people understood how it works. The things I want you to take away from today's service is that there is both something special about the Bible and that it's also very ordinary. It is inspired, in the same way that our classical literature is inspired. It is not a channeled transcription. Instead, it's timeless work with life in it!

The Bible is trustworthy, provided it is handled with integrity, read according to its proper genre, context and purpose. It seems full of lies when we try to twist it into what it is not. The same thing happens with people.

The Bible is not trying to mislead us or lie to us. It is a complicated group of books that requires understanding of the language, cultures, genres, and more. Complex is not the same as fallible. Anytime we try to make the Bible into something that it is not, we end up looking foolish and we miss the opportunity to hear what others have valued for centuries.

I am a serious theologian and a careful scholar. Reason and mystery are important to me. For those fearful patients and families that need to know I'm safe, I can assure them that the Bible is the inspired, inerrant, and infallible Word of God. I can agree that it is indeed a message from God to humankind. I hold the provision that the Bible must be handled with utmost integrity: no cherry picking verses, fanciful interpretations, or sloppy translations. I'm also a good UU, and that means I believe the whole world is full of inspired, inerrant, and infallible messages from the Divine.

Amen and amen